





MOON-WALKERS

1. The launch of Chandrayaan-3 on July 14

2. ISRO control room during Chandrayaan-3 landing on Aug. 23

3. ISRO chairman S. Somanath with the women scientists involved in the Chandrayaan-3 mission at ISTRAC

ing degree from a Chennai college and an M.Tech. from an institute in Tiruchirappalli. A brief stint in HAL preceded his shift to ISRO in 2004, which he joined because it had a "huge brand name". Now, as project director for Chandrayaan-3 for the past four years, on his slender shoulders lay the enormous weight of meeting the nation's space expectations and ensuring that the ISRO brand remained untarnished. As also the prestige of hundreds of Indian space scientists and engineers who have worked tirelessly to make the moon mission a success. Speaking softly but firmly, Veeramuthuvel describes himself as a "simple person" who believes that "self-discipline, 100 per cent involvement without any expectation and hard work never go unrewarded".

Not always, though. Four years ago, on September 6, 2019, he and hundreds of other scientists had to watch the Chandrayaan-2 lander spin out of control 800 metres above the lunar surface and then lose all telemetry contact with mission control as it crashed on the moon. It would fall on then ISRO chairman P. Sivan to break the gloomy news to PM Modi, who was in the visitors' gallery to watch the landing and who had to console Sivan in turn, as pent-up emotion got the better of him. Among those present at mission control that day was S. Somanath, who was then the director of the Thiruvananthapuram-based Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre (VSSC). As he recalls, "We were all sad because we had seen its wonderful performance before that and towards the end we really had no confirmation of whether it had landed safely or crashed because there was no data coming to confirm either way due to the communication failure."

Four years later, the tall, fit and unflappable Somanath